would have been slightly better off, for they would have saved that much money at least.

They came to us in large numbers, complaining bitterly, telling us that they had followed our advice and paid what they could, and this was the consequence. In Allahabad district alone many thousands had been dispossessed, and some proceeding or other had been launched against many thousands of others. The District Congress Committee office was surrounded all day by a distraught crowd. My own house was equally besieged, and often I felt like running away and hiding myself somewhere, anywhere, to escape this dreadful predicament. Many tenants who came to us bore marks of injury, said to have been inflicted by zamindars' agents. We had them treated in hospital. What could they do? What could we do? We sent long letters to the U.P. Government. Our Committee had appointed Govind Ballabh Pant as our liaison officer to keep in touch with the Provincial Government at Naini Tal or Lucknow. He was constantly writing to the Government. Our provincial President, Tasadduq A. K. Sherwani, also wrote from time to time, and so did I.

Another difficulty arose with the approach of the monsoon in June–July. That was the tilling and sowing season. Were the tenants, who had been dispossessed, to sit idle and watch their land lie fallow in front of them? This was very difficult for a peasant; it went against the grain. The dispossession in many cases was legal and technical and not an actual moving away. A court decree had been passed and nothing else had been done. Or were they to plough the land and thereby commit an offence of criminal trespass, perhaps leading to a petty riot? To watch others till their old land was also very difficult for the peasants to tolerate. They came to us for advice. What advice could we give?

I put this difficulty to a high official in the Government of India, when I visited Simla with Gandhiji during that summer, and I asked him what advice he would give if he was in our position. His answer was a revealing one. He said that if a peasant who had been dispossessed asked him this question he would simply refuse to answer him! Even he was not prepared to tell the peasant straight off *not* to till his land, although he had been legally dispossessed. It was easy for him, sitting on the Simla heights, to pass orders on files as if he was dealing with an abstract problem in mathematics. He, or the provincial bosses at Naini Tal, were not brought into touch with the human factor, nor did they see the human misery involved.